Uriah Raffer | JC-523478
Statement of Qualifications

1. Describe your experience in troubleshooting IT issues.

My troubleshooting experience comes from three places. A cybersecurity internship on a Cyber Range built on enterprise infrastructure and tooling, including Microsoft Azure and Tenable. Hands-on trouble tickets in Western Governors University (WGU) labs. And a home lab where the hardware and the software are both mine to fix. I set up the server and storage hardware myself, install the operating systems, and administer Active Directory user accounts and groups, plus Domain Name System (DNS) and Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol (DHCP), across two domain controllers.

In the internship I ran a complete vulnerability remediation cycle on a Windows Server. An authenticated Tenable Nessus scan turned up roughly 30 findings. I prioritized them by impact and ease of remediation, then worked through them one at a time, patching outdated software and hardening insecure settings with PowerShell, re-scanning after every fix so I knew it landed before I moved on. Two findings shaped how I work. Microsoft Edge kept appearing in the results after I had already updated it, because the new version doesn't take effect until the browser is fully closed and restarted. A fix isn't finished when the installer finishes. It's finished when the re-scan comes back clean. A SQLite finding came and went between scans with no action from me, so instead of remediating a ghost I used PowerShell to search the system for SQLite executables and library files, found nothing, and wrote it up as a false positive. Over six scans the server went from 30 findings to 3, about a 90% reduction, with every critical gone by the second scan.

In a WGU lab I took a ticket where half a department kept intermittently dropping off the network, costing people work time mid-task, so job one was getting them back online fast and job two was making sure it stayed fixed. Different machines dropped at different points in the day, which told me it wasn't cabling or one failed device. I traced it to an exhausted DHCP scope with no free addresses left to lease. Widening the scope restored everyone and stopped further disruption, but that treated the symptom. Leases ran a full month, so addresses tied to machines long gone weren't recycling. I shortened the lease time so stale addresses freed up in days, and the problem stayed gone because the cause was gone.

Another WGU ticket started with one end user whose everyday work site kept opening the wrong page. Before touching their machine I asked several other users to try the same site, and when it failed for all of them I knew the fault lived in shared infrastructure rather than on one computer. In Windows DNS Manager I found a rogue forward lookup zone redirecting the domain, removed it, and walked the users through flushing their local cache. Enlisting those users to scope the fault turned a vague one-person complaint into a network-wide fix.

The internship added the investigation side. With a Kusto Query Language query in Microsoft Sentinel I dug into roughly 100 failed sign-on attempts, confirmed a brute-force pattern, and identified the source IP address behind it. I keep the habit sharp at home by deliberately breaking and repairing my own environment, including powering off a domain controller to prove DHCP failover carries address assignment to the

second. The diagnostic tools change from ticket to ticket, Nessus one day and DNS Manager the next, but the method doesn't. Reproduce it, isolate the cause, and verify the fix before calling it closed.

2. What, in your opinion, makes a good IT technician?

A good IT technician fixes causes and proves the fix worked before closing the ticket. Plenty of problems can be made to disappear for an afternoon. The technician who asks why it happened keeps it from coming back, and the one who re-tests never hands the same broken thing back to the same frustrated person twice. A closed ticket that reopens costs more trust than a slow one.

Communication and composure matter just as much. An end user mostly wants to know what's wrong, what happens next, and when they'll be working again, explained at whatever technical level they're comfortable with. I learned composure as a tax preparer at Block Advisors, preparing roughly 70 returns a season under hard filing deadlines. One client took a legally required question personally and asked for another preparer. I stayed calm and respectful, explained why I had to ask, and handed her off without friction, and she finished with an accurate return. Being liked in the moment mattered less than the outcome she left with. Users judge the experience as much as the fix, and a good technician owns both.

A good technician also treats the ticket queue as a set of promises. I take that seriously enough that I built a service desk to practice on. In my home lab I self-hosted GLPI, an open source IT service management platform, and configured it the way a real desk runs. Tickets get triaged with urgency, impact, and priority judged separately. A service level agreement (SLA) sets a response target of four hours and a resolution target of two days, an escalation rule flags anything still open a day before its deadline and moves it to the front, and a routing rule sends network issues to the right team the moment they arrive. The point of managing tickets to SLAs, resolving end user concerns on time and keeping customer satisfaction high, is already how I work.

No technician works alone, and a good one is easy to work with. At Robert's Retirement, when our annuity case manager took a week of vacation, I covered her caseload on top of my own life insurance casework. Much of it was new to me, so I worked directly with the partner company's support team, let them walk me through the unfamiliar steps instead of struggling quietly, and kept both workloads moving all week without a single client complaint. On a busy service desk that same instinct, ask early and keep the team informed, is how a queue stays healthy.

The field doesn't hold still, and a good technician doesn't either. I finished a network engineering degree, added four CompTIA certifications, and keep building labs because reading about a technology isn't the same as running it and breaking it. I write up what I fix, too. My projects are documented step by step on my GitHub so someone could follow them without me in the room, and I seeded the GLPI lab's knowledge base for the same reason, because a fix that lives in one technician's head gets rediscovered the hard way. Those habits, and the eagerness to keep adding to them, are what I'd bring to the End User Support team.